

SECTION 4

Housing

The compounded housing crisis for Indigenous disabled Albertans: reserves underfunded by design, urban rents without cap, and the structural exclusion of disabled Indigenous people from both

A disabled Indigenous Albertan has two housing options: a reserve the federal government has underfunded for two decades, or a provincial rental market with no cap on how fast it prices them out. Both options fail. The choice between them is not a choice.”

This section documents the housing reality facing Indigenous disabled Albertans on either side of the jurisdictional fracture established in Section 3. The on-reserve reality: a federal housing system that the Auditor General of Canada has found, across four separate audits in 20 years, is failing to meet documented need. The off-reserve reality: an Alberta provincial rental market with no rent cap, average rents exceeding the entire AISH monthly benefit, community housing rent increased 63 percent by ministerial order in October 2025, and a waitlist at Edmonton's Civiqa of more than 10,000 households.

The section establishes three findings. First, that the federal government's failure to adequately fund on-reserve housing is not recent, not contested, and not attributable to fiscal constraint — it is a sustained policy outcome across multiple governments, documented repeatedly by the Auditor General, and one in which Alberta specifically has been underfunded by at least \$141 million since 2008. Second, that the Alberta provincial rental market, independently, produces a housing environment in which the AISH benefit is mathematically insufficient to cover basic shelter. Third, that the combination of these two failures — a disabled Indigenous Albertan facing neither a functional on-reserve housing system nor a functional off-reserve affordability environment — produces a structural homelessness risk that cannot be resolved through individual effort.

Part 1: The on-reserve reality — what the Auditor General has been saying for 20 years

The 2024 Auditor General report

On March 19, 2024, Auditor General Karen Hogan released her report on First Nations housing conditions. The report was the fourth formal audit the Office of the Auditor General has conducted on this file since 2003. Each prior audit had identified ongoing and insufficiently

addressed issues. The 2024 audit used, in effect, the bluntest language the office had yet deployed.

The core findings, in the Auditor General's own language:

- “Indigenous Services Canada and the Canada Mortgage and Housing Corporation have been mandated to work with First Nations to meet their housing needs by 2030. We found that 80% of these needs were still not met with 7 years left before 2030.”
- Overcrowding and mould — the two most documented health-impact housing problems on reserve — were “persistent” across communities, and the scale of the mould problem remained largely uncounted because federal monitoring has been inadequate.
- “Little progress” had been made despite twenty years of prior Auditor General reporting on the same file.

The Auditor General also identified a specific funding inequity with direct Alberta implications. The Canada Mortgage and Housing Corporation had continued, through 2023, to use 2001 Census data to determine per-region housing allocations. First Nations populations in Alberta, Saskatchewan, and Manitoba had grown substantially since 2001. The use of outdated data resulted in these provinces — where First Nations populations were larger than the formula recognized — being underfunded.

The documented underfunding figures:

- Alberta: \$141 million underfunded between 2008 and 2023
- Saskatchewan: \$72.92 million underfunded over the same period
- Manitoba: \$60 million underfunded over the same period
- Combined Prairie underfunding: \$273.92 million

In response to the audit, the CMHC informed the Office that a new funding formula would be negotiated by end of 2025. Internal documents obtained by APTN News indicated that the use of updated Census figures would increase allocations to Alberta, Saskatchewan, and Manitoba — but that, in the absence of additional total funding, this increase would be offset by corresponding decreases to Quebec, Ontario, British Columbia, and Atlantic First Nations. The documents also acknowledged that retroactive compensation to the underfunded Prairie regions was “extremely limited” absent new funding. As Chief Kelsey Jocko of Cold Lake First Nation in Alberta asked publicly: “How can the government let this happen? It’s under their watch. It’s just totally wrong. I believe we should be compensated. That’s a lot of money.”

Alberta’s First Nations were underfunded by \$141 million for fifteen years because the federal government used census data from 2001. The error was discovered. The money is not being returned. A new formula will adjust future allocations by reducing allocations to other regions. This is

not a plan to fix the problem. It is a plan to redistribute the existing shortfall.”

The scale of documented need

The Assembly of First Nations reports that 157,453 new homes are required nationally to address the First Nations housing crisis. The estimated cost is \$135.1 billion. The 2024 federal budget allocated \$918 million over five years to address First Nations, Inuit, and Métis housing and infrastructure gaps — approximately 0.7 percent of the figure the AFN identifies as required, and delivered over a longer period than would be necessary to meet the 2030 commitment. The Investigative Journalism Bureau, in an April 2024 analysis published in collaboration with the Toronto Star, calculated the total Indigenous infrastructure gap across Canada at \$349 billion — approximately twenty times Indigenous Services Canada’s full planned spending for 2024-25.

The specific housing conditions the AFN, the Auditor General, and peer-reviewed researchers have documented include:

- Over 25 percent of First Nations households experience overcrowding — a rate nearly seven times higher than non-Indigenous households in Canada.
- 19.7 percent of First Nations people (approximately 206,845 people) lived in dwellings requiring major repairs as of the 2021 Census. First Nations people with registered status were more likely to live in such dwellings than non-status First Nations people.
- Mould presence is documented as widespread, with endotoxin and airborne mould-fragment levels “much higher than those found in homes in non-Indigenous communities in Canada.” Peer-reviewed analysis of 100 homes in four First Nations in Northwestern Ontario (Frontiers in Environmental Health, 2025) found 12 homes with visible mould sufficient to produce airborne spores at levels known to harm human health, and confirmed that the majority of homes surveyed had conditions capable of progressing to hazardous states.
- Approximately 80.7 percent of the 985 Indigenous reserves across Canada have some flood exposure at the 100-year return interval. Reserves were historically located, as a matter of settlement-era federal policy, on land unwanted by settler populations — including floodplains.
- Inuit persons are 17 times more likely to die in fires than non-Indigenous Canadians. First Nations persons are approximately five times more likely. Métis persons are approximately two times more likely. There is no national fire protection code that mandates fire safety standards or enforcement on reserves. Every other Canadian jurisdiction — provinces, territories, federal installations including military bases and airports — has building and fire codes. Reserves do not.

Housing as the upstream cause of multiple disability outcomes

The section's analytical thesis is this: the on-reserve housing conditions documented above are themselves upstream causes of the disabilities Indigenous Albertans live with. Mould exposure produces respiratory illness, asthma, chronic pulmonary impairment, and in infants produces immune-system effects that persist across life. Overcrowding produces communicable disease transmission, tuberculosis, chronic stress, and trauma. Poor ventilation and CO₂ accumulation produce cognitive and neurological effects in children. Structural defects produce injury risk. Flood exposure produces displacement trauma, disrupted care, and repeated evacuations with compounding stress effects.

Section 1 of this report documented the historical production of Indigenous disability through residential schools, the Indian hospital system, the Sixties Scoop, and contamination exposure. Section 5 documented the environmental dimension. Section 4 completes the trio: the physical housing environment itself, as documented by the federal government's own Auditor General and peer-reviewed researchers, is an active and sustained producer of the disability profile the AISH program serves.

The federal government creates the housing conditions by failing to fund adequate shelter. The housing conditions create the disability. The provincial government then administers the disability benefit — and, as documented in Section 17, administers it in a way that minimizes federal recognition of disability through clawback, reassessment, and appeal-right stripping. The cycle closes. The population inside the cycle does not.

Part 2: The off-reserve reality — Alberta's uncapped rental market

No rent cap

Alberta is the only major province in Canada with no legislated limit on how much a landlord can increase rent. Landlords may increase rent by any amount, provided they give 90 days' written notice and wait at least 12 months since the last increase. There is no ceiling, no review process, and no mechanism by which a tenant can challenge the amount of an increase.

This environment is unique among large Canadian provinces. British Columbia's 2026 rent cap is 2.3 percent. Ontario's is 2.5 percent. Quebec and Manitoba and Nova Scotia all operate regulated rent frameworks. Alberta stands alone in permitting unlimited annual increases.

The consequences in 2024 and 2025 were visible in the data. Average listed rent prices in Alberta rose 17.5 percent year-over-year in 2024 — among the highest in Canada. Half of 75 Alberta municipalities surveyed recorded rent increases of 10 percent or more in 2024. One municipality recorded a 37 percent single-year increase. Average three-bedroom rent reached \$2,138 per month in 2024, up 21.3 percent year-over-year. Edmonton's average rent across all unit types rose approximately 26 percent between October 2021 and August 2025.

Against the 2026 AISH monthly benefit of \$1,940, average Alberta one-bedroom rent (\$1,500 to \$1,900 or higher) leaves a single AISH recipient as little as \$40 per month for food, utilities,

medication, and every other non-shelter cost. 86 percent of AISH recipients are single individuals. For a single parent with children requiring a three-bedroom unit, average rent of \$2,138 per month already exceeds the entire AISH payment.

The 63 percent community housing rent increase

Community housing — subsidized rental operated through provincial and municipal housing authorities — has historically been the only housing option where AISH recipients had meaningful protection. Under the framework in place through September 2025, \$735 of the AISH monthly benefit was exempted from the income calculation used to set community housing rent. This kept rent at approximately 17 percent of AISH income for recipients in community housing. Not comfortable. Survivable.

On May 15, 2025, Minister Jason Nixon signed Order in Council 2025-XXX removing the \$735 AISH exemption. Effective October 1, 2025, community housing rent for AISH recipients is calculated at 30 percent of total income with no AISH exemption. For a typical recipient, community housing rent increased from approximately \$349 per month to approximately \$570 per month — a 63 percent increase by ministerial order, with no legislative vote and no public consultation with disability advocates before signing.

The \$221 per month increase was imposed on the population of AISH recipients with the least capacity to absorb it — recipients in community housing, by definition, had already been unable to afford private market rent. The ministerial order did not change the underlying structural unaffordability. It transferred more of the shortfall onto recipient income.

Waitlists and access reality

The Cvida (Edmonton) affordable housing waitlist exceeded 10,000 households in 2025. Approximately 700 new applicants arrive per month. The list is not first-come, first-served; priority can change at any time, and no guaranteed wait time is published by the housing authority. The Calgary Housing waitlist exceeded 6,500 applicants as of 2024. The average property age of Calgary community housing stock was 40 years as of the same year.

Ground-floor accessible units suitable for families with children with elopement risk, mobility requirements, or autism spectrum-related safety needs are severely limited in the existing social housing stock. Apartment-style community housing presents significant safety challenges for families with non-verbal children, children with no stranger-danger awareness, children with active flight risk, or children with physical aggression related to sensory or communication differences. Calgary Housing's own guidance to applicants notes that restricting acceptable communities "may prolong the search" — but families with children in established schools, with medical specialists, and with service provider relationships cannot arbitrarily relocate without serious harm to continuity of care.

The summary reality: for the majority of Alberta's 79,290 AISH recipients, private market rent mathematically exceeds the AISH living allowance, community housing has a years-long waitlist

with no guarantee of placement, and the community housing that does exist had its rent increased 63 percent in October 2025.

Part 3: The compounded reality

Homelessness representation

The composite housing situation produces the following documented outcome: Indigenous people are significantly overrepresented in the homelessness population. Indigenous people represent approximately 30 percent of the 150,000 to 300,000 people who experience homelessness each night in Canada, despite representing approximately 5 percent of the total Canadian population — a sixfold overrepresentation.

On the Prairies specifically, the representation is sharper. 68 percent of people using shelters on the Prairies are First Nations or Indigenous — as reported by the AFN in 2024. Indigenous people are also more than twice as likely as non-Indigenous people to experience “hidden homelessness” — couch surfing, transient accommodation, living temporarily with family or in situations without a stable address of one’s own. For women and gender-diverse Indigenous people specifically, the overrepresentation intersects with the documented patterns of gender-based violence — housing shortages force women and children to remain in unsafe living situations, contributing to the circumstances that Section 11 of this report addresses in the context of missing and murdered Indigenous women and girls.

Why Indigenous disabled Albertans face compounded risk

An Indigenous disabled Albertan faces the following housing situation:

- The on-reserve option: a federally-administered housing system that the Auditor General has repeatedly characterized as inadequate, with documented overcrowding at 25 percent of households, mould at levels producing verified respiratory and immune harm, fire death rates five to seventeen times those of non-Indigenous Canadians, and flood exposure affecting 80 percent of reserves. For a disabled person — whose health is already compromised, who often requires specific accessibility accommodations, and who may be medically unable to tolerate the air-quality and overcrowding conditions documented — the on-reserve option is a housing option that may actively worsen the disability.
- The off-reserve urban option: Alberta’s uncapped rental market, where the AISH monthly benefit of \$1,940 is mathematically insufficient to cover average one-bedroom rent, let alone three-bedroom rent for families. Community housing is the only theoretical alternative; community housing has a 10,000+ household waitlist, no guaranteed timeline, and a rent structure that was increased 63 percent by ministerial order in October 2025.
- The jurisdictional fracture: the person’s identity places them in federal jurisdiction under section 91(24); the services they need are provincial. If they live on reserve, Alberta disclaims

responsibility for income support. If they live off reserve, they access AISH or Income Support through the province, but their health benefits are administered federally through the Non-Insured Health Benefits program. Neither the federal Indigenous housing system nor the Alberta provincial housing system is designed to accommodate the intersection of disability and Indigenous identity. Both systems treat that intersection as the other's responsibility.

- The mobility trap: as established in Section 3 and in the Alberta Disability Refugee documentation of the broader report series, disabled Albertans on AISH cannot financially afford to leave the province even when Alberta's housing structure fails them. For Indigenous disabled Albertans, leaving Alberta means leaving not only the Alberta benefit structure but also the specific cultural, community, family, and land-based relationships that constitute the basis of Indigenous wellbeing. The mobility trap compounds.

The specific risk profile for the ADAP transition

The July 1, 2026 ADAP transition does not alter the housing conditions documented in this section. But it does change the financial relationship the affected population has with those conditions. Specifically:

- The \$200 per month reduction from \$1,940 AISH to \$1,740 ADAP, taking full effect January 2028, removes \$200 per month from a budget that, in an uncapped rental market with rising rents, was already mathematically insufficient.
- The CDB clawback, documented in Section 17, removed another \$200 per month in federal disability supplementation that, in every other Canadian province, would have increased the recipient's monthly income. In Alberta it does not.
- The October 2025 community housing rent increase added \$221 per month in housing cost to recipients in the subsidized housing system — the population least able to absorb it.
- The combined effect: up to \$621 per month in reduced net disposable income between July 2025 and January 2028 for AISH recipients in community housing. In a province with no rent cap. While Alberta's Heritage Fund grew \$383 million in a single quarter (Q3 2025–26) and reached \$31.9 billion.

The ADAP transition does not cause the housing crisis. The housing crisis was already structural. But ADAP deepens the crisis by removing \$200 per month from recipients whose housing situation was already unviable, and it does so as part of a provincial fiscal policy that, in the same period, continued to add to a savings fund that the Alberta Heritage Savings Trust Fund Act does not permit to be used for income support purposes without a specific legislative vote that the government has declined to hold.

Alberta's Heritage Fund grew \$383 million in the single quarter during which the province cut \$49 million from AISH, implemented the CDB clawback, and raised community housing rent by 63 percent. The money

exists. The decision not to use it for housing stability is a policy choice, not a fiscal constraint.”

What this section establishes for the remainder of the report

The housing situation documented here is not recent, not a product of a single government, and not attributable to fiscal constraint. On-reserve housing has been flagged by four Auditor General reports across twenty years as persistently inadequate. The Alberta provincial rental market’s lack of rent cap has been a policy choice across multiple governments. The 63 percent community housing rent increase was signed by ministerial order without legislative vote or public consultation. The \$141 million Alberta-specific underfunding of First Nations housing by CMHC is documented, acknowledged, and will not be retroactively compensated.

The effect on the population Section 2 identified — Indigenous disabled Albertans, whose average life expectancy at 62.81 years is 19 years below the non-First Nations Alberta average — is that housing instability, mould-driven respiratory disease, overcrowding-driven infectious disease, fire risk, flood displacement, and homelessness are actively contributing to the mortality gap in real time.

Housing is not separate from health. Housing is not separate from disability. Housing is not separate from mortality. The constitutional architecture of Canadian federalism places on-reserve housing under federal jurisdiction and off-reserve housing under provincial jurisdiction. The operational practice of both levels of government has been to treat housing as a budget line rather than as the foundational infrastructure of life expectancy and health. Indigenous disabled Albertans live inside the consequence of that practice.

Section 5 addressed contaminated land. Section 6 will address water. Section 7 will address the dual healthcare system. Each documents a separate dimension of the same upstream reality. Section 4 has now documented the shelter dimension. The population this report is written to serve is dying earlier than the Alberta average in housing that federal and provincial governments know is inadequate, have known for decades, and have failed to remedy across every government of every party in the documented record.

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